recommended that we should call off the trip. However, I didn't agree and asked the pilots to give it a try provided the weather permitted. Soon we were on our way. What greeted us fifteen minutes into the flight was a scene unlike any I had ever seen before. Vast green plains changed into a narrow river valley with densely forested hills. The helicopter threaded its way in the valley, flying along the Dihing river. The view was unbelievable – and surreal. We were overflying the famous Namdapha reserve forest, home for much of our wild life, particularly the great Indian hornbill and a few remaining tigers. Finally, we reached Vijaynagar, where a colourful reception awaited us. We landed on a disused runway, which used to have regular maintenance and communication sorties of AN 32 transport aircraft of the air force till 2007. Despite the isolation and difficult living conditions, the people were warm and welcoming. This was the first visit by a governor in recent times to this place, and a big crowd had gathered to meet me. After the welcome address by the circle officer and my response, the people's representative handed over to me a memorandum of their demands, which I admit were very genuine. I assured them that I would do my best to ameliorate their problems and distributed gifts to the village heads and 'gaon buras' and a cash grant to the circle officer for the welfare of the people. Then I went across to the Assam Rifles post and interacted with the soldiers. I was very pleased to see the state of morale of the gallant officers and men of 18 Assam Rifles.

On the way back, I pondered over the plight of these people. Their ancestors were settled here with promises and they trusted us blindly. So, I decided that if I was to pick one single development challenge facing the state, it would definitely be to provide road connectivity to these 6000 or so inhabitants of Vijaynagar area, and to do so with a sense of urgency. To begin with, I initiated the idea of a jeepable fair-weather road connecting Miao to Vijaynagar, a distance of approximately 175 kilometres. Thereafter, the state government released some funds and the work commenced. The chief engineer, Toli Basar, a dedicated official, had promised to complete this task by January 2011 subject to weather conditions.